

Terabyte

One Terabyte is one thousand billion bytes, or 1,099,511,627,776 bytes

Quick Fact

The world's first hard drive, IBM's RMAC was introduced in 1956 with a capacity of 5 MB

Market Share

Seagate - 30.5%
Western Digital - 17.6%

Another dilemma faced by most buyers is whether to buy an external case and a hard drive and combine the two to make your own solution or simply buy a ready-made external drive solution. Both methods have their relative merits, but I tend to prefer the former. For me, a warranty of three to five years on a finished product is worth the premium any day. Also, many vendors sell very cheap drive enclosures, as they are called, and quite frankly, they aren't very long lasting. A couple of users have reported damage to their hard drives by using these cheap cages and while I do not know how exactly the damage occurred, there's no point taking a risk, especially when loads of valuable data are involved. In my opinion, Western Digital is the most popular brand in the market as of now in terms of external 2.5-inch solutions. Seagate has just entered the Indian market with some very interesting options. Of course they've been in the 3.5-inch HDD market far longer. These brands use their own hard drives in such enclosures. You can buy just the hard drive (meant for notebooks as they are 2.5-inch drives) and buy an enclosure. Transcend, Lacey and Zippy are the three brands that sell a lot of enclosures. Mind you, these brands do not manufacture hard drives so you will need to buy a hard drive from one of the above mentioned brands. There are also several manufacturers who sell external solutions. WD, Seagate, Iomega, Freecom and Transcend are the big players and you will find quite a few offerings from them in the market, with WD and Seagate being the biggest sellers and also the most popular. Iomega and Freecom are slightly costlier. The reason for this, I assume, is because they don't manufacture HDDs of their own. Seagate and WD also have the best warranty policies and the highest number of service centres — something that should also be taken into account.

For those looking at sheer speed, Seagate offers its *FreeAgent XTreme* drives. Unfortunately, these are based on the bulkier 3.5-inch desktop HDDs, but they offer the blazingly-fast SATA 2.0 interface. At Rs. 9,500 for the 500-GB version, and Rs. 10,000 for the 640-GB version, these are worth the speed, especially for those wanting really snappy transfers and are willing to shell out accordingly. Obviously the Serial-ATA interface also helps overcome the bottlenecks associated with USB and even FireWire.

For the data hog, I recommend WD's 320 GB Passport. At Rs. 6,300, this is one of the best options around. I own a 160 GB WD external solution and am happy to report it has given me trouble-free service for the past two years, in spite of the rough handling it has borne. For someone looking at a smaller capacity solution, I recommend 160-GB solutions from WD. 80-GB solutions are barely 600 bucks cheaper and not worth it, according to me, unless you really cannot afford to spend more. WD Passport 160 GB for Rs. 3,100 is sweet. If you really are a behemoth to back up and store data, look at Seagate's *Free Agent* 500 GB or WD's *Passport Elite* 500 GB. This is the largest 2.5-inch solution money can buy. Unfortunately, these solutions are highly priced — Rs. 12,000 for Seagate and Rs. 14,100 for WD. I bought the 320-GB WD for Rs. 6,000 after bargaining for a bit. And in my opinion, this offers the best of both worlds — it performs well and has oodles of storage. Best of all, it doesn't break the bank.

In the desktop internal HDD space, it seems that the prices of the 500 GB-and-above segment have fallen, and fallen drastically. Everybody is going for 500-GB hard drives these days and even 250-GB and 320-GB hard drives are being overlooked. I was looking at buying two very large capacity hard drives — one for my friend's voracious appetite for movies and another for me to replace the two 250 GB drives in my PC. And this is another reason to upgrade. Two hard drives consume twice as much power as one, not to mention they take up twice the space as

well. With a single 1-TB hard drive, I would get a cool 500 GB more than both my older 250-GB hard drives would give me. WD's new *Black Series* are fast, but expensive. In fact, they are more expensive than Seagate's options. The 750-GB WD *Black Edition* is priced at Rs. 6,400, while the 1-TB version costs around Rs. 8,200. I say not cheap, because in comparison, the new Seagate 1 TB 7200.11 series hard drive is priced at a lowly Rs. 6,500! For the price, this drive is an absolute steal — it's fast, runs cool and is in no way inferior to WD's *Black Series* offering. In fact, we recently tested this drive and found it to be quite a performer. Seagate has also launched a 1.5-TB hard drive and is retailing for as low as Rs. 8,300, which is nearly the same price as the 1-TB WD *Black Edition*. I find the thought of a 1.5-TB hard drive as a backup drive giving me shivers up my spine. What I do is keep a large internal hard drive as a spare. I connect this to my PC once a month and backup all my downloads, movies and games; for longevity purposes, I disconnect this hard drive and store it carefully. So at any one time, I have at least two backups of all my data. My external drive is used solely for copying data to and from my office, home PC and my notebook.

We also came across Seagate's latest 7200.12 series hard drives which are very new in our markets. Sadly there's no 1.5 TB offering yet and the maximum size is one terabyte. I really liked this drive as the acclaimed read speed was 160 MBps. This drive is priced at Rs. 6,800 and is still pretty affordable. I ended up buying one, and paid Rs. 6,750 for it and got a cool five year warranty. My friend wanted something bigger (gasp!) and we eventually settled on the massive 1.5 TB Seagate *Barracuda* 7200.11 for Rs. 8,200. This hard drive is the largest in the world in terms of storage space as of now, and makes a very suitable purchase for someone looking at buying the largest capacity drive available. Obviously, when WD's two terabyte offering releases this drive will relinquish its lofty perch. But that's another story. It's fast too and after testing it, I can tell you that it runs fairly cool. I can tell you the store owner was rubbing his hands in glee and he told us he had never sold so many gigabytes worth of hard drives to a single party. For those of you who cannot count, we made off with some 2.82 terabytes of total storage, or a little more than two thousand, eight hundred and twenty gigabytes. ■

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Toshiba acquires more space

It's a well-known fact that Fujitsu had been struggling for quite some time now. This financial year alone, it had forecasted its losses to be around \$500 million. With such tremendous losses, it has decided to shelve off its hard drive division to Toshiba. On the other hand, Toshiba hopes to gain a strong position in the enterprise-class solid-state disk (SSD) drive market. It will also be able to leverage Fujitsu's expertise in the 2.5-inch HDD space, in which it is currently the leader. The deal will also fast-track Toshiba to enter the HDD market for enterprise servers and data storage system applications. It now expects this deal to raise its overall share in the HDD market to over 20 per cent in the coming years. The deal is to take place in two stages with Fujitsu retaining 20 per cent of its stake for some time. However, this is not the first time someone had their eye on ailing Fujitsu. Western Digital had made an estimated offer of \$950 million some time back, but the deal fell through because of cultural differences. The value of the current deal is not known. Fortunately, layoffs don't seem to be on the card as a result of the buyout.